Chapter 5

Mother Teresa Hugs
India's Most Admired Woman

IN 2002, KIRAN WAS VOTED THE MOST ADMIRED WOMAN IN INDIA AND the fifth most admired Indian (according to a poll conducted by the *The Week* magazine, 15 September 2002). The large numbers of votes she polled were astonishing compared to others who were established icons in their respective fields. The tally was as follows: Kiran Bedi 466 votes, followed by Lata Mangeshkar (385), Sonia Gandhi (261) and Sushma Swaraj (253). She was also polled as the most popular 'social worker' (2009) by *Hindustan* (a Hindi daily newspaper).

Earlier, Kiran had become the role model for a number of movies. *Kartavyam*, in Telugu (released in 1990 and later dubbed in Tamil as *Vijayashanti I.P.S.* and in Hindi as *Tejaswini*), starring actress Vijayashanti in the role of a Kiran Bedi clone, won the first national award for the actress. Kiran performed the *mahurat* (a ceremony to mark the auspicious beginning or launch of a project) and even gave a few tips to the producers on how to go about writing the actual script. As the title of the film (meaning 'duty') indicates, it deals with a police officer's sense of duty and dedication to service. The movie was well made and deservedly won an award for itself. There were television serials, too, based on Kiran's life such as *Stri* and *Inspector Kiran*. The movies and serials have been well researched by the directors and their teams through a study of write-ups on Kiran in the press as well as through personal interviews with her. Her image among the public at large is what has been attempted to be captured on celluloid. The reviews in the media as well as the public response provide ample evidence of her being accepted as portrayed in the aforementioned films and serials.

The sterling qualities that emerge from the movies/serials centre round integrity. She has been projected as being an upholder of the law who is very impartial in dispensing justice to the offender. She has also been shown to have been subjected to tremendous pressure by the nexus between the criminal businessman and the corrupt politician and to have successfully overcome all obstacles by her sheer determination, mental tenacity and an inflexible, uncompromising attitude when she knows and believes she is right. As far as emotions are concerned, she has been shown to have tremendous restraint.

When asked what she thinks about how she has been portrayed, Kiran feels that, barring a few exaggerations that are the wont of our film makers, the portrayals are quite realistic. 'They've even kept the heroines quite slim', she giggles, 'but they seem to have an edge over me in their being very tough in the stunts they perform.'

But tough she is when it comes to the powerful who try to throw their weight around or bully the police because of the public position they hold. Kiran is then at her angry best. For proof, one has only to hear her colleagues recount various episodes. In her approach, she is non-sparing whoever the individual may be – in power or expected to be. What matters to her at that moment is the situation